

Community Immunity Project

Your Town Didn't Vote for This: Inside the Fight to Build "Herd Immunity" Against AI Data Centers



BEACON OF HOPE

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There's a pattern playing out in small towns across America right now, and if you haven't lived it yet, you probably know someone who has.

A rural county gets a call from a developer. Within months, a data center the size of a small airport is under construction — approved through a zoning process most residents never heard about, some of it settled in meetings held after dark. Then the bills start arriving: electricity rates that jumped from \$50 to \$300 a month. Well water that runs murky brown. A 24/7 industrial hum that doesn't stop, that gives people headaches and keeps them up at night. When the town tries to push back — a moratorium, a lawsuit, a zoning challenge — the company sues the town for enforcing its own rules, and a city with a

budget the size of a Silicon Valley signing bonus finds itself facing a legal bill it cannot survive.

This isn't a rumor or a one-off horror story. Erin Brockovich's crowdsourced mapping project has collected over 10,000 submissions from residents in 49 states, all describing versions of the same thing. Nearly 80 municipalities have already passed bans, pauses, or moratoriums trying to slow it down. The pattern is consistent enough, and widespread enough, that it stops looking like bad luck and starts looking like a business model.

That's the starting point for a new proposal called the **Community Immunity Project** — an attempt to stop treating each of these fights as an isolated local skirmish and start treating them as outbreaks of the same underlying disease.

The Problem With Fighting One Town at a Time

Here's the uncomfortable truth the Project starts from: individual communities cannot win this fight alone. A single town filing a lawsuit against a data center operator is, in immunological terms, a **macrophage response** — fast, local, and completely overwhelmed by a well-funded, well-lawyered adversary that has done this dozens of times before and knows exactly how the fight goes.

Meanwhile, the same handful of corporations move from municipality to municipality, using near-identical contracts, near-identical NDAs, and near-identical playbooks for suppressing resistance. Every town starts from zero. Every town relearns the same lessons the hard way. And the company gets better every time.

That asymmetry — a coordinated, repeat player against a series of first-time, isolated defenders — is exactly why individual fights keep losing even when the facts are overwhelmingly on the community's side.

Building the Adaptive Immune System

The Community Immunity Project's core idea is to stop relying on that macrophage response and instead build something closer to an **adaptive immune system**: a nationally coordinated architecture that turns every local fight into a permanent antibody — legal precedent, public evidence, a replicable playbook — that the next town can use without starting over.

It's organized around four phases that map directly onto how your body actually fights disease:

1. Signal ingestion. A network of mobile-friendly, no-technical-skill-required intake portals lets residents upload utility bills, zoning minutes, noise recordings, and whistleblower documents. This scales up what Brockovich's mapping project already proved works — turning individual, isolated complaints into a structured, searchable body of evidence.

2. Pattern recognition. Raw reports alone don't move regulators or courts. The Project proposes building out a semantic knowledge graph that connects the dots explicitly: this facility, permitted by this zoning vote, draws this many gallons a day from an aquifer serving these households, whose water quality began degrading this many months later — cross-checked against official records, not just anecdote. It also proposes an **Exploitation Harm Index (EHI)**, a standardized way to quantify the scope and severity of harm so it can withstand legal and regulatory scrutiny rather than being dismissed as anecdotal.

3. Human verification. Any automated system that flags "exploitation" patterns runs the risk of false positives that could discredit the whole effort. So before any finding becomes public or triggers enforcement, it passes through a mandatory human review panel — cross-validating community reports against court dockets, EPA data, and utility filings. The design principle here is blunt: unimpeachable in court means unimpeachable before it's ever published.

4. Institutional memory. Validated findings go into a permanent, public **Harm Registry** — a searchable record of exactly which tactics a given corporation used and what harm resulted, organized so a town council in Kansas can look up what happened in Georgia before their own vote. The idea is that a corporation caught repeating the same harmful pattern in a second town, after it's already documented in the Registry, faces real consequences — not just another fine it can write off as a cost of doing business.

Making It Safe — and Worth It — to Speak Up

A system like this only works if people are actually willing to report what they see, and the Project spends real effort on that problem. Municipal employees — the city clerk who saw a midnight zoning vote, the engineer who knows a water permit is being violated — are often sitting on the most valuable evidence and taking the biggest personal risk by sharing it.

So the proposal builds in anonymous, encrypted submission channels, legal aid funding for whistleblowers, and federal whistleblower protections triggered automatically on submission. On the incentive side, it leans on a mechanism already established in the underlying legislative framework: successful citizen enforcement actions can return 25–40% of any financial recovery to the person who documented and filed it, with legal fees shifted to the losing corporation. The goal is to make coming forward not just safe, but rational.

Why Data Centers, Specifically

The Project treats the AI data center boom as a deliberate pilot case rather than the whole mission. It's a good starting point for a few concrete reasons: the evidence base already exists (Brockovich's 10,000+ reports), the pattern is unusually consistent across states (making it easier to prove this is systemic rather than isolated), and roughly 79 communities are already organized and looking for tools

rather than needing to be recruited from scratch. It's also a story that's easy to explain to just about anyone, regardless of politics: a company is draining your water, spiking your bill, and suing your town for objecting.

But the architecture itself isn't built to be data-center-specific. The same intake taxonomy, the same knowledge graph, the same harm index are explicitly designed to be extended to other forms of extraction — predatory lending, wage suppression, medical necessity denials — using the data center fight as the proof of concept.

The Bigger Bet

Strip away the biology metaphor, and the proposal is making a fairly simple bet: exploitation survives because it's invisible, and every mechanism that currently protects it — the NDA, the after-hours zoning vote, the shell-company ownership structure, the fine written off as a line item — is a form of manufactured obscurity. Make the pattern visible, make the harm measurable, make the same-town-twice repetition trigger real personal accountability for the executives who signed off on it, and the economics of the whole strategy change.

Whether this specific architecture gets built at the scale the proposal imagines is an open question — it's an ambitious, multi-year undertaking that depends on legislative movement, sustained funding, and a lot of local organizing energy holding together. But the underlying diagnosis is hard to argue with: as long as every town has to fight this fight alone, from scratch, against a repeat opponent that never has to relearn anything, the outcome is predictable. The only real question is whether communities start fighting this the way the corporations already do — as a coordinated, systemic effort — or keep losing one town at a time.

Planet over people over profit.

The immune system doesn't negotiate with the pathogen — it identifies, documents, contains, and eliminates it. And then it remembers.